only factor that kept a significant number of Lashkar recruits from fighting in Iraq. The overwhelming majority of foreign fighters there were from elsewhere in the Middle East, North Africa and Saudi Arabia.[146] Even many of these men found operating in Iraq difficult because they spoke a different Arabic dialect and were not familiar with the terrain. Given that Lashkar recruits were South Asian, they had even less hope of navigating the Iraq theater. Nor were there robust networks in place for fighters to travel from South Asia to the Iraq theater, compared with the numerous channels for would-be jihadis from the Arab-speaking world. Meanwhile, for those members of the group who did want to fight against the US, Afghanistan was next door. Thus, it is not surprising that despite Lashkar's hyperbolic announcements, few of its fighters actually turned up in Iraq.

Lashkar's operational commander Zaki-ur Rehman Lakhvi is believed to have directed a small number of operatives to travel to Iraq in 2003 and followed up by dispatching additional cadres as well as funds to attack American forces in Iraq in 2004.[147] In the spring of 2004 British forces captured two Lashkar militants there. Both of them were handed over to the US, which sent them to a prison in Afghanistan.[148] One of those captured reportedly had been Lashkar's operational commander in charge of the forward camps from which cadres were launched across the LoC, a position he held from 1997–2001.[149] The Pakistani security services reportedly came down hard on the group once the presence of its cadres in Iraq was brought to Musharraf's attention. The British Foreign Office also alerted Musharraf to the fact that the captured Lashkar cadres had the phone numbers of ISI agents in their mobile phones. According to the senior British Foreign Office official who provided this information, Musharraf dealt with the specific ISI agents involved.[150] Whatever the consequences for Lashkar, its domestic operations were not seriously affected.

A Training Provider and Gateway Organization

The US counter-attack had destroyed the training infrastructure in Afghanistan. The major Pakistani groups were able to maintain some instruction capacity within Pakistan, but their capabilities varied. Lashkar continued operating larger camps more overtly than other groups in Mansehra and Pakistan-administered Kashmir; it also ran smaller ones in FATA, mainly in the Waziristan and Mohmand agencies, not far from where